

CHAPTER 18 — Three Hunters

By Friday morning, the tracker was eighty-three miles east of the cottage and still moving.

Voss watched the dot cross a paper map spread over the bonnet of his car.

The operational phone gave him the cleaner picture: road numbers, estimated speed, time since last transmission. The paper map gave him what the screen concealed—terrain, alternative routes, bottlenecks, places where a vehicle could disappear without appearing to.

He marked the latest position with a short line of pencil.

A refrigerated lorry passed the roadside pull-off, shaking water from the carriageway. One corner of the map lifted. Voss caught it without looking up.

Reyes arrived three minutes later in the grey estate car.

He parked at an angle, occupying enough space to discourage anyone else from stopping, then crossed the wet tarmac carrying three cardboard cups.

“Black,” he said, placing one beside Voss’s left hand. “No sugar.”

Voss examined the lid.

“You marked it.”

“You complained last time.”

“I identified a preventable error.”

“You drank Vale’s coffee and spoke about it for forty minutes.”

“It had sugar in it.”

“That explains the optimism.”

Reyes placed the second cup on the bonnet and kept the third.

He had remembered that Vale took no sugar and refused powdered milk. He remembered details like that while insisting he did not care

whether other people survived the day comfortably.

Voss took the coffee.

"You passed the cottage track twice."

Reyes drank from his cup.

"Good morning to you too."

"The second pass was unnecessary."

"The first established the road. The second checked the response."

"You may have created the response."

"Nothing moved."

"The occupants were gone before dawn."

Reyes looked at the map.

The tracker dot moved another fraction east.

"He found the device Tuesday."

"Yes."

"Then why did it reappear yesterday?"

"That," Voss said, "is why we are here."

Vale arrived at eight exactly.

She parked beyond the estate car, nose facing the road, and walked towards them with her coat buttoned to the throat. She accepted the coffee Reyes held out, removed the lid and smelled it before drinking.

"No powdered milk," Reyes said.

"I can see that."

"You smelled it."

"I don't trust your eyesight before nine."

"You've trusted it in worse places."

"Those places did not serve vending-machine coffee."

She looked at the map.

"What changed?"

Voss pointed to three pencil marks.

"Tracker stopped transmitting in the valley Tuesday morning. Silent for forty-seven hours. At six fourteen yesterday it reappeared here."

His finger moved to an all-night freight stop beside an A-road.

"Four minutes later it began travelling east. Average speed fifty-two. One stop of eleven minutes. Another of twenty-six. No route variation that looks like evasion."

"Commercial traffic," Vale said.

"Probably."

Reyes leaned against the bonnet.

"Or he wants us to think that."

"Yes."

"So we ignore it."

"No."

Reyes looked at him.

Voss folded one side of the map against the wind.

"A false trail still tells us something. Where it began. How it was transferred. What he expected us to do. Mac paid for three people because he wanted certainty. We do not create certainty by ignoring the only signal we have."

"Mac paid for recovery."

"Mac paid for obedience," Vale said. "That is not the same thing."

Reyes gave her a sideways look.

"You spent one evening in his office."

"It was enough."

Vale placed her document case on the bonnet and removed a photograph of the cottage track.

Reyes's dashboard camera had taken it during his second pass on Wednesday. Trees obscured most of the buildings. The rusted gate remained closed across the track. Beyond it, only a section of stone wall and the upper corner of a shutter were visible.

"Tell me exactly what you saw," Vale said.

Reyes looked at the photograph rather than her.

"A track. Three buildings in the wider valley. One occupied farm. One agricultural outbuilding. One cottage difficult to see from the road."

"People?"

"Dog walker near the entrance. Tractor farther up. No confirmed target."

"The shutter?"

"Closed."

"Completely?"

Reyes enlarged the image on the operational phone.

A narrow dark line divided the wood.

"Not completely."

Vale studied the gap.

"Somebody inside could have watched the road."

"Could have."

"You passed once slowly. Came back three minutes later. They left before dawn."

"That proves timing."

"It establishes a sequence."

Reyes peeled the paper sleeve from his coffee cup in one continuous strip.

Voss had seen him do that before a port extraction nine years earlier, when a customs officer noticed the wrong seal on a vehicle none of them were supposed to be near. Vale had solved the problem. Reyes had remembered her coffee ever since.

"We have no evidence anyone inside identified the car," Reyes said.

"No," Vale replied. "We have a route change after your second pass. That is enough to keep the possibility open."

Voss drew a circle around the valley.

"Reyes stays local. Find the property, the abandoned vehicle, tyre marks, anything that establishes departure direction."

Reyes looked towards the moving tracker dot.

"And you?"

"I follow the device."

"Even though it is probably attached to a lorry."

"I know nothing until I touch it."

Vale closed her case.

"I'll trace the cottage through records."

"There are three buildings," Reyes said.

"There are three buildings. Property is a legal condition."

He smiled without humour.

"That sounded expensive."

"It usually is."

Voss folded the map.

"One-hour checks while mobile. Thirty minutes inside the search radius. No private phones. Nobody enters a confirmed site alone."

Reyes dropped the peeled sleeve into his empty cup.

"You wrote that rule for me."

"I wrote it after you."

"That is almost affection."

"No," Voss said. "It is documentation."

They separated at eight twenty-three.

The tracker had begun moving east the previous morning.

Thursday, before sunrise, Elias and Zoe had finished sweeping the second car beneath the trees beyond the cottage stream.

No transmitter.

No fresh wiring.

No unexplained magnets.

No device hidden behind the lights or wheel liners.

Zoe held the torch while Elias checked the underside one final time.

"Same rule," she said. "Assume nothing because it belongs to you."

"It doesn't belong to me."

"That makes it worse."

"It usually does."

The cottage hatchback remained hidden inside the barn behind the warped doors.

Elias kept Mac's tracker in his coat until they reached an all-night freight stop beside the A-road.

Rows of trailers occupied the rear yard beneath white security lights. Some were attached to sleeping cabs. Others waited detached behind numbered bays.

The tracker sat in the cup holder between them, battery reconnected, the green indicator pulsing.

Zoe looked through the windscreen.

"You said taking it gave us another choice."

"It does."

"What choice?"

"Where they look next."

He nodded towards the detached trailers.

One refrigerated unit carried markings for an eastern distribution depot. A route card sat inside a clear plastic holder beside the coupling.

Zoe read it from outside the barrier.

"Somebody will collect it."

"Yes."

"And whoever is following the tracker follows them."

"Until they prove the trailer has nothing to do with us."

"What if they stop the driver?"

"They should verify first."

"That isn't what I asked."

Elias looked across the yard.

A shunter moved between trailers at the far end. A man in a reflective jacket smoked beside the office door. Somewhere behind the café wall, plates struck one another in a sink.

"There is risk," he said.

"To somebody who knows nothing about us."

"Yes."

Zoe held the tracker in her palm.

Without the hatchback around it, the device looked too small to have

altered two days of their lives.

"We need another way."

"This is the cleanest one I have."

"That means the others are worse. It doesn't make this good."

"No."

He did not take the tracker from her.

Two lorries entered the yard.

Zoe watched the trailers, the office and the road back to the A-road.

"What happens when they see it moving?"

"They decide whether I transferred it or whether the hatchback is travelling inside something larger."

"So they check."

"Yes."

"And while they check, they are east."

"Yes."

"How long?"

"Best case, two days. Worst case, two hours."

She looked at the route card.

"Use the detached trailer. Not a cab."

"That was the plan."

"You didn't say."

"I'm saying now."

"And nowhere that makes the driver look involved."

"I can reduce that risk. I cannot make this risk-free."

Zoe looked at him.

He waited.

Finally she handed back the tracker.

Elias placed it behind the trailer's rear underrun structure, concealed from casual view but not enclosed inside the metalwork.

When he returned, Zoe was watching the yard office.

"Did anyone see?"

"No."

She raised an eyebrow.

Elias corrected himself.

"No one reacted."

That answer satisfied her more.

They waited from the public road until a white tractor unit entered the yard, coupled to the refrigerated trailer and carried the tracker east.

Only then did Elias drive west.

They reached the farmhouse late Thursday morning.

The farmhouse had once been painted white.

Weather had removed most of the evidence.

It stood beside a disused dairy yard with six empty stalls, a corrugated machinery shed and a rectangular pond covered in green weed. The road ran closer than it had to the cottage, hidden only by poplars and a stone wall low enough for a person to look across.

The building was less private and more useful.

Two entrances. A pantry. A working range. Water from a borehole. A rear staircase narrow enough to defend and a front staircase wide enough to escape down quickly. The upstairs windows overlooked every approach except the drainage ditch behind the shed.

Elias showed Zoe that first.

Doors.

Windows.

Keys.

Fuse box.

Escape routes.

Only then did he show her the bedroom.

The farmhouse did not sit behind the same identity as the cottage.

Years earlier, a former associate had arranged the place through a small agricultural-management company that no longer traded. Elias's current name did not appear on the visible lease, and neither did the older surname attached to the cottage. The rent had continued through an intermediary account Elias replenished once a year without visiting.

The arrangement was not invisible.

It was merely buried under a different layer.

Zoe had learned enough by then to recognise the difference.

The second car was a dark estate model older than the one that had passed the cottage. Its paint had faded unevenly. The passenger window required both hands to close.

One set of farmhouse keys hung from a nail beside the rear door.

Elias handed the second set to Zoe.

She put them in her pocket.

No speech accompanied it.

The backpack remained with her.

On Friday morning, rain entered through a cracked pane above the kitchen sink and began dripping onto the table. Zoe's backpack sat beneath it.

Elias found her upstairs, standing on a chair to test whether the bedroom window opened fully.

"The bag is getting wet," he said.

Zoe climbed down.

"You moved it?"

"No."

"Why not?"

"It is yours."

They went downstairs together.

She moved the backpack to the dry end of the table. Elias placed a saucepan beneath the leak.

Later, before washing upstairs, Zoe aligned the two zip pulls precisely over the centre seam.

When she returned, they had not moved.

At lunch she left the backpack beneath the table instead of looping a strap around one ankle.

Elias noticed.

He said nothing.

Reyes spent Friday driving the valley.

He changed vehicles after lunch, replacing the grey estate with a builder's van carrying ladders and a company name printed badly enough to discourage inspection.

He stopped at the occupied farm and asked whether anyone had seen two loose dogs.

He spoke to the tractor driver about a blocked culvert.

He bought eggs from a box beside the road and paid twice the requested amount because he had no coins.

By evening, he had collected fragments rather than certainty.

One resident remembered a dark hatchback turning into the valley late Monday night.

Nobody he spoke to remembered seeing it leave.

The cottage gate had remained closed Tuesday and Wednesday.

No girl matching Zoe's general description had been seen on the public road.

Reyes did not enter the cottage.

Voss's rule was irritating, not optional.

At six, he reported from a petrol station twenty miles away.

"No departure sighting," he said. "Car may still be on-site."

"Then wait for Vale," Voss replied.

"You are one hundred and forty miles east."

"I am aware."

"The tracker is following a freight corridor."

"I am also aware of that."

"So why are you still following it?"

"Because Mac has asked every twenty minutes whether it is attached to a freight vehicle."

Reyes looked at the forecourt cameras and moved farther beneath the canopy.

"Tell him yes."

"I do not report conclusions before evidence."

"That is why conversations with you take so long."

Vale joined the call from a records office in a market town outside the valley.

"The visible cottage is held by a company dissolved eleven years ago," she said. "Land Registry correspondence leads to an accountant who died six years ago. Companies House gives me two older registered addresses. Council records list the property as intermittently vacant."

"Elias?" Voss asked.

"No direct name."

"Indirect?"

"Possibly. One historical company address overlaps with a residential address used by a different surname nineteen years ago."

Reyes stopped pacing.

"His?"

"I said possibly."

"So his."

"No," Vale said. "That distinction is why you are waiting."

Reyes looked towards the road.

Traffic moved past in both directions.

"Tomorrow morning," he said. "We go in."

"Together," Voss said.

"You are following a refrigerator."

"I will return when I have confirmed it."

"That could take another day."

"Then the cottage will remain empty for another day."

Reyes opened his mouth.

Vale spoke first.

"If the original car is there, leaving it may be part of the message."

Reyes glanced at the operational phone.

“What message?”

“That we are behind.”

“We already know that.”

Vale looked down at the records in front of her.

“No. We know he wants us to feel it.”

Saturday passed at the farmhouse without a repeated vehicle on the road.

Absence required work.

Elias walked the outer boundary before sunrise and again after dark. Zoe watched the road from three different windows but was not given another version of Wednesday’s observation exercise.

“Repeating it too quickly teaches you to perform the exercise,” Elias said. “I want you noticing the world.”

Instead, he spread the road atlas across the kitchen table.

“Show me where the tracker is going.”

“I don’t know where it is.”

“Assume the route card was accurate.”

Zoe traced the A-road east, found the distribution corridor and marked three likely depots with dried beans.

“Why three?”

“You said trailers get redirected.”

“Good.”

“You said no praise for answers that are only sensible.”

“I said good to the number of possibilities.”

“That is still praise.”

“File a complaint.”

"With who?"

"There is always someone with a form."

Zoe moved one bean farther east.

Elias placed two more on the map.

"Whoever is searching for us has choices. Follow the tracker. Keep searching the valley. Investigate where the cottage came from."

"You think they split the work."

"I think competent people would."

"How many?"

"We don't know."

"More than one."

"Probably."

She moved one bean back towards the cottage.

"One search follows the tracker. One stays where it disappeared. One follows who you used to be."

Elias examined the map.

"Why the third?"

"Because the cottage wasn't connected to Elias."

He had not told her that directly.

She read the question in his face.

"You used a key from inside your wallet. The other car was registered to another name. This farmhouse is hidden differently again. If they can't follow where you are, they follow what you left behind."

Elias sat back.

"That is what I would do."

"I know."

“How?”

“You keep paying for things you say you left behind.”

The answer reached farther than the map.

Elias moved the third bean into the blank margin.

“What does that mean?” Zoe asked.

“It means the records search may be the dangerous one.”

“Because it might find this place?”

“Because it might find something I stopped looking at.”

Zoe waited.

Elias folded the eastern side of the map over the beans.

He did not explain.

She did not ask again.

The silence was not surrender.

It was credit extended against future conduct.

By Sunday morning, Vale had an identity bridge.

She built it without touching a private solicitor’s archive.

Land Registry gave her the dissolved company that had held the cottage.

Companies House gave her historical officers, registered offices and a dead accountant.

Archived planning records supplied one correspondence address the modern databases had dropped.

Commercial tracing records connected that address to a house divided into flats nineteen years earlier.

One former occupant used a surname that disappeared shortly before Elias’s current paper history began.

Not proof.

A route.

Vale photographed only the pages she needed and built the chain in order.

At twelve forty, she called Voss.

"I have an identity bridge."

"How strong?"

"Strong enough to explain access to the cottage. Not strong enough to explain the man."

"Name?"

"I'll send it through the secure channel."

"Mac?"

"Not yet."

Voss stood at an eastern distribution depot watching refrigerated trailers reverse beneath numbered bay lights.

"Why not?"

"Because his file on Elias begins after the older identity disappears. Either Mac did not check, or he checked and decided the answer was inconvenient."

"Which do you believe?"

Vale looked at the sequence of addresses on her screen.

"Mac does not strike me as a man who forgets to check."

"Then he withheld it."

"Or someone built the current identity well enough that even Mac preferred not to disturb it."

Voss watched another trailer reverse into Bay Fourteen.

The tracker dot remained stationary somewhere inside the depot.

"What does the older name tell us?"

"Not enough yet."

"Service?"

"No record."

"Police?"

"No record."

"Criminal?"

"No record."

"Then it tells us he changed names."

"It tells us he changed one without leaving the debris people usually leave."

Voss looked across the rows of white trailers.

"Meet Reyes at the cottage."

"I already told him."

Vale reached the cottage shortly after one.

Reyes waited beyond the gate in the builder's van.

He had not entered.

That earned him no praise and irritated him anyway.

The gate was still closed.

They approached on foot.

Reyes examined the lock, worked on it briefly and opened it without damaging the mechanism.

Vale did not ask how.

They crossed the yard.

The front room smelled faintly of extinguished fire.

Two bowls had been washed and placed upside down beside the sink. A deck of cards sat inside its box with eleven missing. One pantry shelf showed a cleaner rectangle where food had recently stood.

Vale examined the front window.

A chair had been positioned beside it, not directly in front. One pair of leg marks was fresher than the dust around them.

She sat.

The shutter gap aligned naturally below the eye line of a standing adult.

"Now I think it was the girl," she said.

Reyes opened the shutter fully.

"You don't know that."

"No."

"Could have been him."

"He would have had to sit low."

"People sit."

Vale stood.

"And thirteen-year-olds watch roads."

Reyes looked through the gap towards the public road.

They searched room by room.

No folder.

No hard drive.

No clothes.

Nothing obviously useful without laboratory processing.

In the barn, behind the warped doors, they found the hatchback.

The clamp damage remained at the front wheel. Road dirt covered the

rear quarter except for the disturbed section behind the liner.

Reyes crouched and found the adhesive residue.

"Tracker came from here."

Vale stood at the barn entrance.

"He discovered it after arrival."

"He should have found it before."

"Perhaps it was installed somewhere he trusted."

Reyes scraped at the edge of the residue without removing it.

"Mac."

"His service yard."

Reyes looked back at her.

"He sent us after a man he had already prepared to disobey."

"He prepared for disobedience."

"Same thing from this side."

Vale watched him circle the car.

Reyes was not careless. That was what made the brief increasingly difficult to accept. A careless man would have made him contemptuous. An incompetent one would have made him quick.

Elias was making him attentive.

Attention sat badly on Reyes. It gave pride more time to become personal.

"Nothing indicates departure direction," he said.

Vale looked towards the orchard.

"Not by road."

They found the path to the stream ten minutes later.

On the far bank, tyre impressions remained in the soft ground. Rain and runoff had damaged them, but the width did not match the hatchback.

"Second vehicle," Reyes said.

"Stored in advance."

"His?"

"Probably another identity."

Reyes stood and looked through the trees.

"What kind of driver keeps vehicles beside forgotten houses?"

Vale did not answer.

She was beginning to think the word driver existed in Mac's brief for the same reason curtains existed over windows.

Not to describe what was inside.

To prevent people looking.

Sunday passed at the farmhouse without a vehicle slowing on the road.

Elias repaired the passenger window using a length of wire and a piece of rubber cut from an old boot.

Zoe wrote a supply list on the back of a feed invoice.

Soap.

Batteries.

Fresh food.

Socks.

A second torch.

Painkillers.

Sanitary products.

Elias read the list once.

He did not hesitate over the final item or ask a question designed to disguise discomfort as concern.

“What kind?” he asked.

Zoe told him.

He added the detail in his own handwriting so he would not forget.

After lunch, rain began striking the kitchen windows.

Zoe sat at the table with the backpack beside her chair and tried to repair one of its straps using thread found in a drawer. The needle was blunt. The fabric resisted.

Elias watched her make the same failed stitch twice.

“May I?”

She considered the bag.

Then handed him the loose strap without releasing the rest.

He took only the damaged end.

His stitches were small, even and unexpectedly neat.

“Who taught you?”

“Someone who got tired of repairing my work.”

“Still in your life?”

“No.”

Zoe waited a moment.

Elias drew the thread through and tied the final knot.

She did not ask more.

He returned the strap.

She tested it.

“Better.”

“That is close enough to gratitude.”

“It was a quality assessment.”

“Even better.”

Later, when Zoe went upstairs, she left the backpack beneath the kitchen table.

Elias stayed at the range.

He did not touch it.

Voss found the tracker on Monday morning.

Mac had supplied the tracker’s serial number and a fleet-security explanation sufficient to persuade the depot manager that a proprietary telemetry unit had been attached to the wrong trailer.

The manager remained beside Voss anyway.

The tracker was fixed behind the rear underrun structure of a refrigerated trailer that had completed three routes since Thursday.

Nothing suggested Elias or Zoe had been near the cab.

Voss photographed the device before removing it.

The casing bore knife marks.

The battery connector had been separated and reattached.

A smear of black adhesive remained along one edge, different from the grey road dirt surrounding it.

Deliberate removal.

Deliberate reactivation.

Deliberate transfer.

The depot manager shifted his weight.

“Is it police?”

“No.”

"Insurance?"

"No."

"What is it, then?"

Voss sealed the tracker inside an evidence bag.

"A message."

The manager looked at the black rectangle.

"To who?"

Voss looked at the road map on his phone, then at the evidence bag.

"Us."

The three hunters regrouped Monday afternoon in a quarry café halfway between the valley and the eastern depot.

Lorry drivers occupied the tables nearest the counter. Wet coats steamed beside radiators. A television mounted in one corner showed a daytime programme with subtitles and no sound.

Voss placed the evidence bag between the sugar dispenser and the laminated menu.

Reyes looked at it.

"He sent you two hundred miles for that."

"He sent all of us somewhere."

Vale unfolded a copy of the title history and the identity chain she had built.

"The cottage was real. The hatchback was there. They left on foot and used a second vehicle beyond the stream."

"Direction?" Voss asked.

"Unknown."

"Road cameras?"

"Three possible exits. Two have no useful coverage. The third

overwrites after seventy-two hours.”

Voss removed his pencil and drew three lines on the paper place mat.

Reyes watched him.

“We lost them.”

“For now.”

“They have had four days.”

“Yes.”

“And you think the girl made my car.”

“Probably,” Vale said.

Reyes rubbed one thumb across the side of his coffee cup.

Small habits survived bad information.

“What did Mac know?” he asked.

Voss looked up.

“About what?”

“The old identity. The cottage. The tracker being installed in his yard. The fact that his driver knew how to move it without breaking the trail.”

Vale turned the page over.

“He knew enough to pay us more than the brief justified.”

“That is not an answer.”

“No.”

Reyes looked at the evidence bag.

“He told us one man and a child.”

“That may still describe the number of people travelling,” Voss said.

Reyes laughed once.

"Three contractors. Four days. Two hundred miles. One empty cottage. Accurate is doing a lot of work."

Voss drew a circle around the three possible road exits.

"The mistake is assuming speed helps us. He expects pressure to make us narrow too soon."

"So we widen."

"We rebuild Thursday from the beginning."

Vale shook her head.

"Wednesday."

Voss waited.

"The second pass mattered. Now we know somebody light used the chair at the shutter. The girl was probably watching the road."

Reyes looked towards the television.

"She is thirteen."

Vale's reply remained level.

"She is also the person Mac's paperwork reduced to cargo."

"She is not trained."

"No," Vale said. "Which may be why she notices things trained people classify as ordinary."

Voss turned the pencil between his fingers.

"Then the target model changes."

Vale nodded.

"Elias is not making every decision alone."

Reyes looked from Vale to Voss.

"You are giving a child too much credit."

Voss drew a second circle beside the first.

"No. We gave her none. That was less accurate."

At the farmhouse, Monday evening settled without rain.

Zoe placed three beans on the map.

One at the cottage.

One on the eastern distribution corridor.

One in the blank margin.

"How long?" she asked.

Elias stood at the sink washing two mugs.

"Until what?"

"Until whoever followed the tracker knows it was moved."

"They may know already."

"You said best case two days."

"I did."

"It has been four."

"Yes."

"So they took it."

Elias dried one mug.

"I think so."

"You said that like you knew."

"I shouldn't have."

Zoe looked at him.

Most adults repaired uncertainty by becoming louder.

Elias repaired it by reducing the claim.

"What do you know?"

"That nobody has approached the farmhouse. No vehicle has repeated. No local question has reached the neighbour at the road junction. If the tracker was ignored completely, I expected more pressure in this region by yesterday."

"Expected."

"Yes."

"So the diversion probably worked."

"Yes."

She moved the eastern bean farther away.

"And now?"

"Now whoever followed it knows they were moved."

"That makes the tracker search slower."

"Probably."

"The local search faster."

"Possibly."

She tapped the bean in the blank margin.

"And whoever is checking your old names?"

Elias placed the clean mug upside down.

"More interested."

"Which is worst?"

"The records search."

"Because they might find what you stopped looking at."

Elias paused.

The phrase had been his on Saturday.

"Yes."

Zoe gathered the beans.

Elias reached towards the backpack to clear it from the folded map, then stopped before touching it.

Zoe saw.

She lifted the bag herself and placed it on the other chair.

Neither commented.

The boundary had been observed.

Elias folded the map.

“Whoever Mac sent is good.”

Zoe fastened the repaired strap.

“So are we.”

He did not correct her.

Outside, beyond the poplars, an ordinary car passed on the road and continued without slowing.

Both listened until it was gone.